But Aleksander's story does not end there. He too had a great interest in economics. In fact, his red star helped him to make a career that he had probably never even dreamed about. He was even able to found and run a relatively autonomous economics institute in Ljubljana, the Slovenian capital. As the Yugoslav and, in particular, the Slovenian socialist economy was flirting with the logic of capitalist economy, his institute grew in fame.

But his most nonconformist act came much later: his book, *Berman's Dossier* (written in Slovenian), was a bulky volume of a thousand-plus pages which few read in its entirety and it was completed almost literally on his deathbed. It shook many in Slovenia. By then, books critical of the Communist system were not that rare anymore. But it was shocking that Bajt, a respected scientist and a former partisan comrade himself, should present an utterly revisionist and devastatingly critical account of the partisan resistance and the Communist revolutionary movement.

Ljubo too got involved. With his eternal, almost naïve belief in the intrinsic good of mankind, he accepted after the democratic changes the challenge offered by a new political party (born out of the Socialist Youth Organisation that rebranded itself as the Liberal Democratic Party) and unsuccessfully ran for President of Slovenia, only to later feel that he had been used as a figurehead by men who did not exactly share his passionate and deep belief in liberal democracy. This word will feature prominently in the second part of this book.

Each of the three classmates could tell his own personal story about Eastern Europe as they knew it and each of these stories is so characteristic of Central and Eastern Europe to which this book is dedicated. Throughout it, the three terms (Central Europe, Eastern Europe and Central and Eastern Europe) will often be used interchangeably, as they often are in the English-speaking world, though I will also explain the distinctive nature of different parts of what is commonly known as Eastern Europe. This is also the main subject of the first part of the book.

Today, the Berlin Wall has been down for some time and the countries of the region safely in the European Union and NATO. Over the period of 30 years, knowledge about the region, including popular knowledge, has improved considerably. But the rise of Mr Kaczyński in Poland and Mr Orbán in Hungary and the region's reaction to the migrant crisis in 2015 have once again raised questions about the meaning of what is called